

map and a creative DM can use this feature to give more background information about a location, such as descriptions of items in the room or back stories. On top of that there is a pretty sophisticated drawing toolbox, that allows you to create shapes, and scribble directly onto the map. Note that the eraser tool works a bit differently, always deleting the whole shape or line or patch of paint drawn, instead of selectively erasing out only the parts that you move over. There are just enough features to make this a great tool to use quickly and out of the box.

Talespire

TaleSpire is in Early Access and is in the early stages of product development, so there is a lot of potential for where this tool can go in the future. It is essentially like a 3D version of



Inkarnate, allowing DMs to craft custom maps by using preset assets in a digital library included within the app. Right now, there are only a few tiles and not a lot of range, but it is still sufficient to create experiences for most regular campaigns. Each of the users can move their own characters, with tools for measuring distance and area of effect. From the DM's side, things can get pretty complicated with making doors, fog and even ambient soundscapes. The DM can craft the entire campaign in-game, with multiple maps for the players. For the players, the whole experience is a lot like straight up playing a videogame.

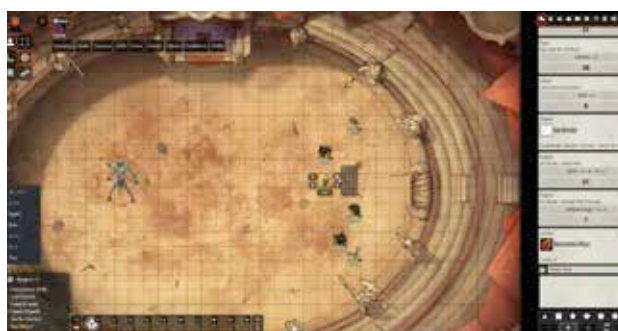
The good thing about Talespire is that it plugs in directly to your DnD

Beyond accounts. Users can also send messages to chat in the game itself, and there is a really funny emote system that keeps getting more complex. All the dice needed for rolling can be thrown onto the board itself, bouncing off the figures, which is a nice way of doing it. Creating maps is a fast and easy process, but the really great thing about this software is the ability to create complex, layered three dimensional maps. So it is totally possible to create a multi storey house for people to explore on their own for example. The great thing is that the DM can go into the build mode and change stuff around in realtime, even when there are players already in a party. There are a few drawbacks to Talespire though, the software costs about ₹569 and requires all the players to purchase a copy, it is fairly demanding in terms of system use, and it is easy to

stress out a laptop where Discord and Talespire are being used at the same time, which is a frequent scenario. Navigating the software is pretty complex, especially when it comes to changing the

levels, and going higher up or underground, or underwater that can take some getting used to. However, as we mentioned, this is a software that is still in Early Access, and is getting better all the time.

Foundry VTT



Foundry is a 2D environment, where the DM just loads the maps, imports the characters from DnD Beyond, and you are good to go! The VTT in the name stands for Virtual Tabletop, and that is exactly what this is. Once the characters are loaded, you get to pick all their spells and attacks from a handy list available on the interface. Many of the common spells and attacks have really cool animations, and the funny thing is that if you roll and miss, than the animation attack misses too! The really cool thing about Foundry VTT is a cone of vision, where the DM does not have to create a fog, it gets created automatically. Only what the players can see is lit up, which can be an interesting experience as users waiting just outside a door for example, may not be able to see what the rest of the party is doing within a room, something that is difficult to pull off in other virtual tabletops. The underlying system is powerful and modular, supports mods and is very flexible. There are a lot of things you can do with Foundry, and the software strikes a good balance of simplicity and features.

This is a web app and not a standalone app, which is problematic in its own way, at least in terms of consistency of experience. The app does take quite some time to load, is demanding on system resources, and can randomly freeze or crash the browser. While only the Dungeon Master needs to pay for Foundry to allow all the players to access the instance, it does require the use of Hamachi or Zerotier to set up a virtual LAN among the players if many people need to use the tool. However, the good thing

about Foundry is that it is flexible enough and works almost the same even if the DM only streams their own version, without allowing the others to participate in the game at all. *